

HOME-BASED TEST KITS

There are at least nine ICMR-approved home-based RAT kits in the market ranging from ₹250 to ₹350 per kit

APPROVED BY ICMR

1. Mylab Discovery Solutions

2. Alere Medical (Abbott)

3. Tata Medical and Diagnostics

4. Meril Diagnostics

5. Angstrom Biotech

6. Siemens Healthcare (Healgen Scientific)

7. S.D. Biosensor Healthcare

8. Nulife Care

9. Trivitron Healthcare



UNDER VALIDATION BY ICMR

1. Oscar Medicare

2. Pathkits Healthcare

3. Labcare Diagnostics (India)



“The customer needs an instant test at low cost as soon as symptoms show up, without stepping out. The market for self-test kits will grow at least for the next two years”

HASMUKH RAWAL

MD & CO-FOUNDER, MYLAB DISCOVERY SOLUTIONS



“Along with our Express PCR instrument, the RAT kit provides quick PCR reports at a large scale, ideal for locations like airports and hospitals”

DR V. RAVI

HEAD-R&D, TATA MEDICAL AND DIAGNOSTICS

tors, chemists, and dispensaries to maintain sale records of RAT kits, along with addresses and mobile numbers of the buyers. Those selling the kits have to also ask the buyers to download an application of the manufacturer and upload their test reports. If the buyers test positive, they have to inform the nearest government hospital or their doctor, and update the report onto the online ICMR portal. Still, there are concerns. “While regulating the sale and use of these testing kits is ideal, uploading of results would still depend on the end user,” says Mahajan of Mahajan Imaging.

The Road Ahead

Experts say that the future of these tests would depend on the trajectory of the pandemic. “Since, in due course, Covid-19 is expected to become endemic, the long term us-

age of these tests may be limited,” says Mahajan.

But the market of home-based tests and Covid-19 testing at large is transforming. For instance, Abbott has globally introduced 12 different Covid-19 tests to work in a variety of settings and stages of infection, including the fastest molecular point-of-care platform, lab-based molecular and serology tests, professional rapid antigen tests, and self-tests. “India’s diagnostics sector is evolving rapidly, encompassing novel innovations in testing across a variety of point-of-care settings. This has spurred the decentralisation of testing and the formation of the newest category of self-testing,” says Sunil Mehra, General Manager for Abbott’s Rapid Diagnostics Business in India.

The quality of self-testing technologies is improving, too. For example, one of the latest home-based

Covid-19 testing kits by Abbott is Panbio Covid-19 Antigen Self-Test, which has reported a sensitivity of 95.2 per cent and specificity of 100 per cent, indicating high accuracy in detecting active infections, especially in more infectious cases with higher viral load.

Epidemiologists, however, are concerned that with home testing, the epidemic curve of the coronavirus may not show the real burden of the disease. “Home tests are very convenient, but the onus is on the user to not become a source of infection for others by behaving carelessly,” says Lalit Kant, former head of epidemiology and communicable diseases at the ICMR.

So, if you test positive, inform the authorities. And if you test negative but have symptoms, take an RT-PCR test. Without fail. **BT**

@neetu_csharma